WHITEPAPER

FinOps Response Portal MVP

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Purpose

This MVP defines the smallest useful version of the AI-assisted FinOps response workflow.

The goal is not to build a broad FinOps agent. The goal is to remove the slowest, most manual part of the current process:

- FinOps sends a report item to the owning team.
- The team needs enough context to respond.
- The response must be structured, auditable, and dashboard-ready.
- Reassignment and disputes must be captured without mutating catalogues or AWS resources.

The MVP delivers one controlled response workflow for one report feed, one approved model, one authenticated internal UI, and S3-backed state/export.

MVP Outcome

At the end of the MVP, FinOps can send a user a secure link for a specific report item. The user authenticates, reviews AI-assisted context, submits a controlled response, and the system writes an auditable S3-backed output that dashboards can consume.

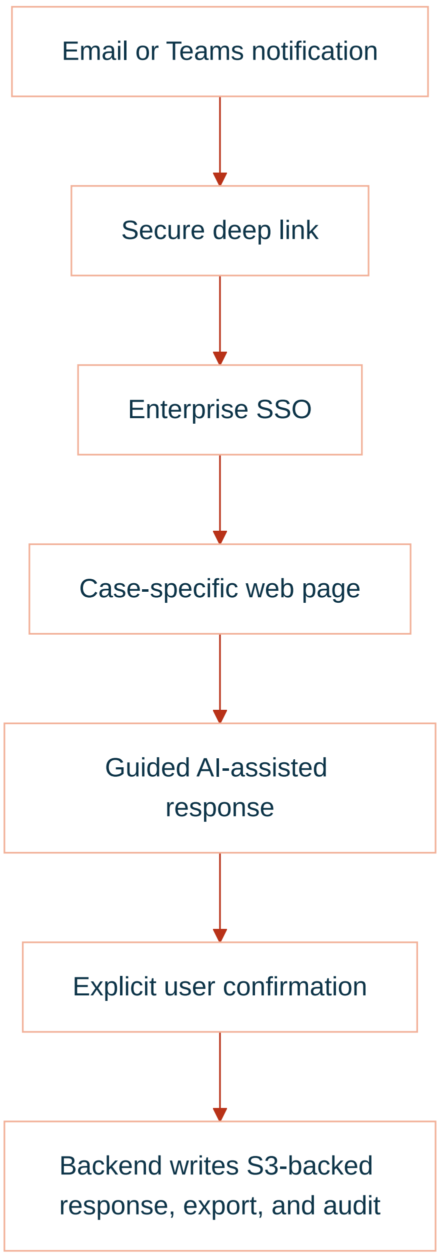
The value is:

Value	MVP Mechanism
Faster responses	Case-specific explanation and guided response
Better dashboard commentary	Structured response schema
Lower chasing effort	Status captured centrally
Safer AI adoption	Bedrock only assists; backend owns all writes
Clear audit trail	View, draft, submit, and export events recorded

User Interface Model

The MVP has one canonical user interface: an authenticated internal web case page.

Email and Teams are notification and entry channels. They are not the system of record and they do not replace the case page for final review.



Primary Interface: Case Page

The user interacts with a single case page for one report item.

The page must make three things obvious immediately:

Question	UI Answer
What is this issue?	Summary, cost delta, service, period, current owner
Why did I receive it?	Assigned team/application/product and responder group
What can I do now?	Four controlled response actions

Minimum page layout:

Area	Contents
Header	Issue ID, status, due date, report period
Assignment panel	Product, application, team, responder group
Cost panel	Service, cost delta, currency, detected drivers
Evidence panel	Links to source report, dashboard, change records if present
AI guidance panel	Plain-English explanation and follow-up questions
Response panel	Controlled form for justification, dispute, reassignment, or investigation
Review panel	Final structured response preview before submission
Audit strip	Last updated, submitted by, current state

The page is not a general chatbot. It is a guided response workspace for one authorised case.

User Actions

The user gets four primary actions.

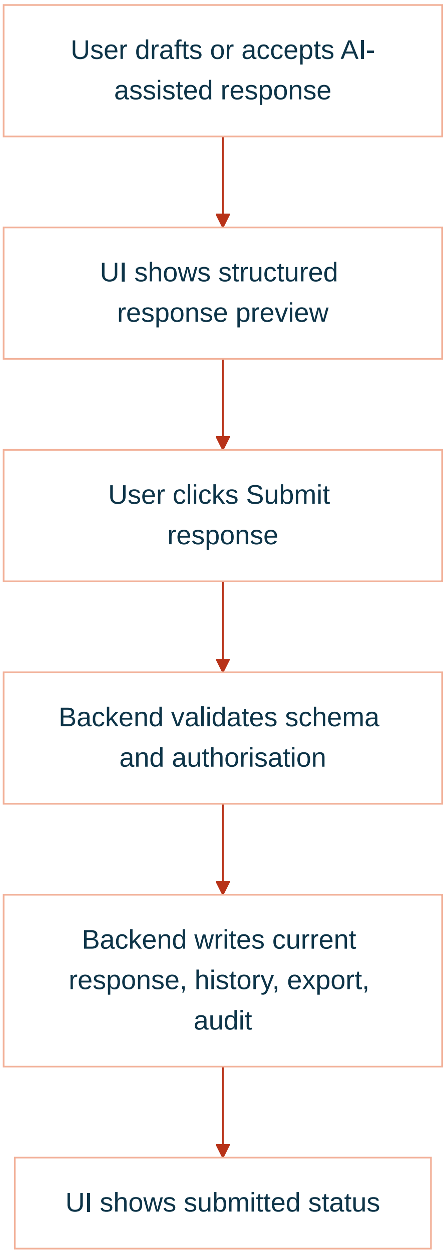
Action	UI Pattern	Backend Result
Provide justification	Guided form with AI-assisted drafting	`justified` response written
Dispute issue	Structured challenge reason and notes	`disputed` response written
Request reassignment	Proposed owner/application/team fields	`reassignment_requested` response written
Mark needs investigation	Reason and optional next step	investigation state written

Secondary actions:

Action	MVP Behaviour
Ask for explanation	AI explains the current case file only
Improve wording	AI drafts clearer finance-friendly wording
Classify response	AI suggests controlled category; user confirms
Attach evidence link	User adds URL/reference metadata; backend validates shape
Cancel	No response write; audit may record view/session only

Final Submission Flow

Every final response follows the same pattern.



There is no hidden model action after the user clicks submit. The backend writes only the reviewed structured response.

Email Interface

Email is used for notification only.

Minimum email content:

Field	Example
Subject	`FinOps response required: Checkout API EC2 increase`
Issue summary	`EC2 spend increased by £18.5k for May 2026`
Assigned owner	`Payments / Checkout API / Payments Platform`
Due date	`2026-06-07`
Action link	`Open response case`

The email link contains report ID and issue ID only. It does not grant access by itself.

```text
https://finops-response.internal.company/report/monthly-2026-05/issue/finops-2026-05-001234
```

Teams Interface

Teams can be added in the MVP if the organisation already supports Teams app/bot deployment. It should still call the same backend API.

Recommended Teams scope:

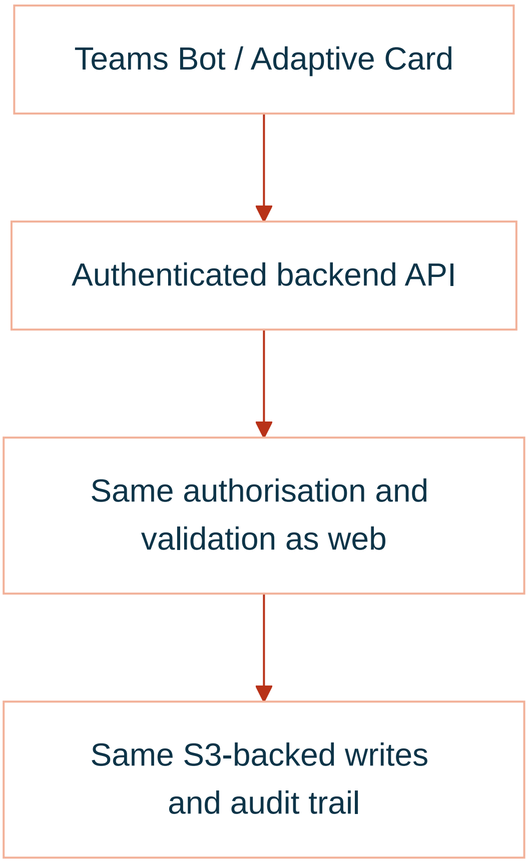
Teams Feature	MVP Use
Bot notification	Tell assigned team a response is required
Adaptive Card	Show summary, due date, status, and action buttons
Open case button	Deep link to the authenticated web case page
Reminder message	Notify before due date or when status changes
Lightweight response	Optional for simple `needs investigation` or short justification

Teams should not be the only interface for complex responses. Complex justification, disputes, reassignment, and evidence review should open the case page.

Teams card actions:

Button	Behaviour
Open case	Opens the canonical web page
Ask AI to explain	Calls backend; returns case-scoped explanation
Mark needs investigation	Opens confirmation or case page
Request reassignment	Opens case page with reassignment action selected

The safe pattern is:



Interface State Model

The case page should expose state clearly.

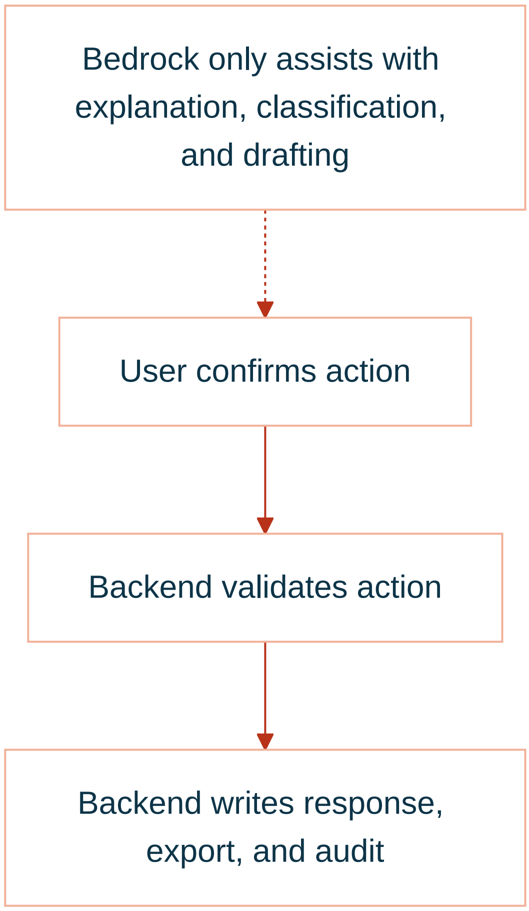
UI State	Meaning	User Experience
Awaiting response	No final response submitted	Primary actions enabled
In discussion	User has started but not submitted	Draft visible, submit still required
Submitted	Final response written	Read-only summary plus audit details
Pending FinOps review	Dispute or unclear response needs review	User sees review state
Reassignment requested	Proposed new owner captured	User sees pending approval
Closed	No further action needed	Read-only

Interface Acceptance Criteria

Requirement	Acceptance Test
User understands why they received the case	Case page shows current assignment and responder group
User understands the financial issue	Case page shows period, service, cost delta, and drivers
User can act without free-form email	Four controlled response actions are available
User can review before submit	UI shows structured preview before final write
AI assistance is bounded	AI panel only references current case context
Teams/email are not security boundaries	Opening a link still requires SSO and backend authz
Dashboard data is produced	Submit creates dashboard export record
Audit is complete	View, assist, submit, and write events are recorded

Non-Negotiable Constraint

The model is not the system of record and does not write to AWS services.



Smallest Useful Scope

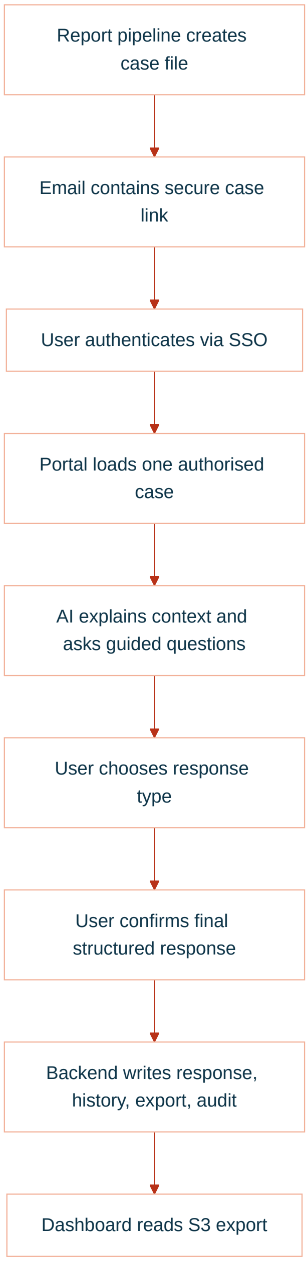
In Scope

Capability	MVP Definition
One report source	A pre-built case file per report item
One notification route	Email deep link to the internal app
One authenticated UI	Web page with case details and guided chat
One model	One approved Bedrock text model
Four response types	Justification, dispute, reassignment request, needs investigation
S3-backed storage	Case files, current response, history, export, audit
Dashboard export	One S3 prefix with dashboard-ready JSON or Parquet
Audit events	Views, model assists, submissions, export writes

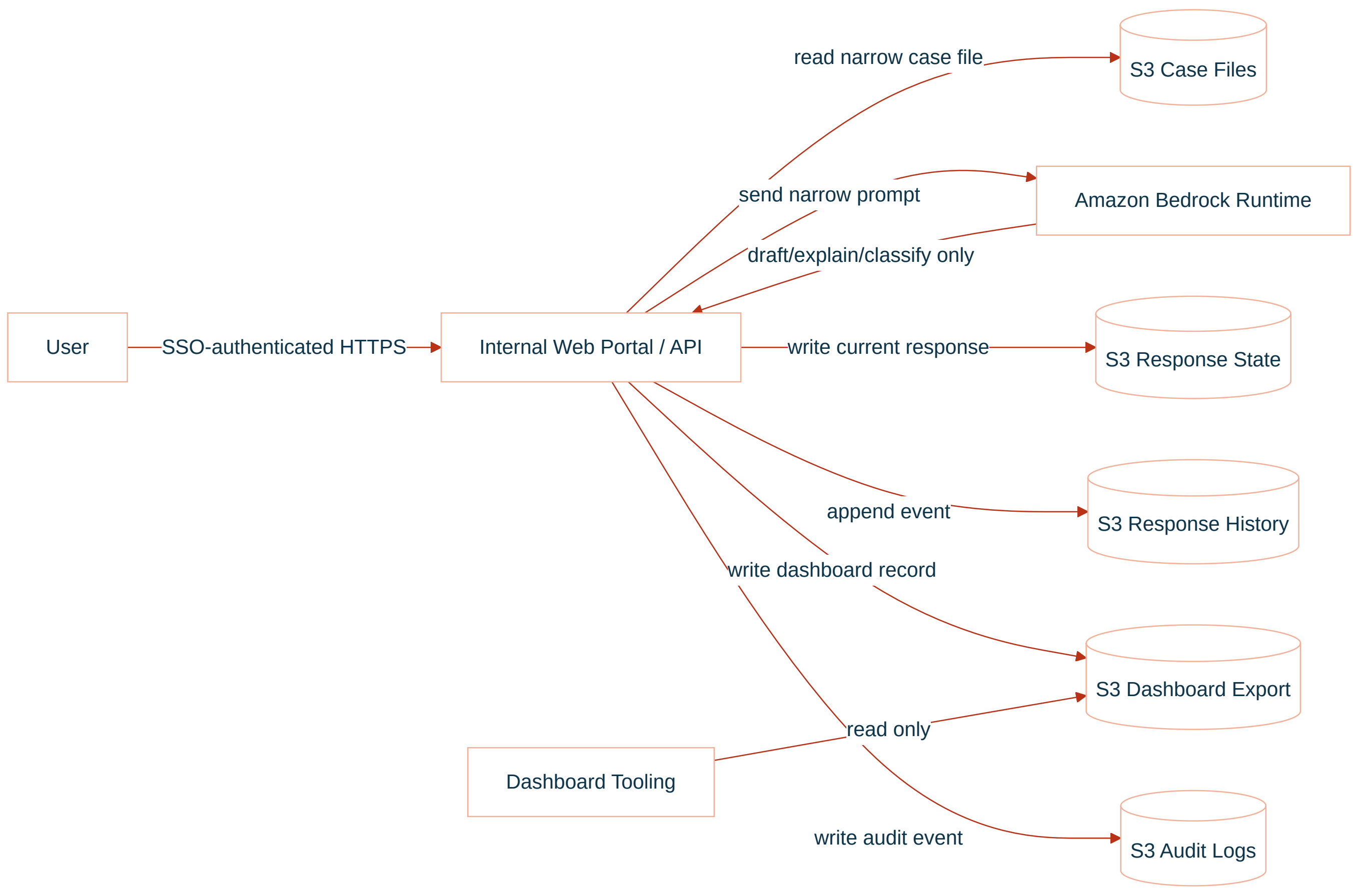
Out of Scope

Excluded	Reason
Autonomous remediation	Not required to capture FinOps responses
Raw CUR access from the app	Case files are generated upstream
Live AWS infrastructure inspection	The app does not diagnose resources directly
IAM, tag, billing, or catalogue mutation	MVP captures requests only
Broad chatbot over all cost data	Interaction is scoped to one case
Direct browser-to-S3 writes	Backend must validate and audit all writes
Multiple model providers	One approved model is enough to prove value

MVP User Journey



MVP Architecture



Case File Contract

The upstream report pipeline creates one case file per report item. The MVP app reads this file; it does not query raw CUR directly.

Minimum case file:

JSON


```json
{
  "issue_id": "finops-2026-05-001234",
  "report_id": "monthly-cloud-report-2026-05",
  "report_period": "2026-05",
  "status": "awaiting_response",
  "assigned_team": "Payments Platform",
  "assigned_product": "Payments",
  "assigned_application": "Checkout API",
  "service": "AmazonEC2",
  "cost_delta": 18500.25,
  "currency": "GBP",
  "summary": "EC2 spend increased materially versus prior month.",
  "detected_drivers": [
    "c7g.4xlarge running hours increased",
    "EBS gp3 usage increased",
    "Production autoscaling floor appears higher"
  ],
  "allowed_responder_groups": [
    "payments-platform"
  ],
  "response_due_date": "2026-06-07"
}
```


Response Types

Type	User Intent	Final Status
Justification	Accept the spend and explain why	`justified`
Dispute	Challenge data, amount, service, or allocation	`disputed`
Reassignment request	Suggest a different owner	`reassignment_requested`
Needs investigation	Cannot explain yet	`in_discussion` or `pending_finops_review`

Response Contract

The backend writes one current response and one immutable history event.

JSON


```json
{
  "issue_id": "finops-2026-05-001234",
  "response_id": "resp-001",
  "response_type": "justification",
  "status": "justified",
  "submitted_by": "user@company.com",
  "submitted_at": "2026-05-21T14:30:00Z",
  "justification_category": "expected_business_growth",
  "business_reason": "Traffic increased due to new merchant onboarding.",
  "technical_reason": "Additional production capacity was required.",
  "expected_to_continue": true,
  "requires_finops_review": false,
  "ai_summary": "The team accepted the increase as expected business growth."
}
```


Dashboard Export Contract

The dashboard does not need the full transcript. It needs a compact, trusted record.

JSON


```json
{
  "report_period": "2026-05",
  "issue_id": "finops-2026-05-001234",
  "product": "Payments",
  "application": "Checkout API",
  "team": "Payments Platform",
  "service": "AmazonEC2",
  "cost_delta": 18500.25,
  "currency": "GBP",
  "status": "justified",
  "response_type": "expected_business_growth",
  "response_summary": "Increase accepted due to merchant onboarding and higher baseline capacity.",
  "submitted_by": "user@company.com",
  "submitted_at": "2026-05-21T14:30:00Z",
  "requires_finops_review": false,
  "requires_catalog_update": false
}
```


S3 Layout

Use one bucket or approved bucket set. Keep prefixes explicit.

```text
s3://<bucket>/case-files/report_period=2026-05/issue_id=finops-2026-05-001234.json
s3://<bucket>/responses-current/report_period=2026-05/issue_id=finops-2026-05-001234.json
s3://<bucket>/responses-history/report_period=2026-05/issue_id=finops-2026-05-001234/event_ts=...json
s3://<bucket>/dashboard-export/report_period=2026-05/team=payments-platform/part-....json
s3://<bucket>/audit/report_period=2026-05/issue_id=finops-2026-05-001234/event_ts=...json
```

Authorisation Rule

```gherkin
User is authenticated
AND user belongs to the assigned responder group OR FinOps admin group
AND issue exists
AND issue is open
AND requested response type is allowed
AND final response passes schema validation
```

Prompt Boundary

The model receives only:

Context	Included
Issue summary	Yes
Current assignment	Yes
Detected drivers	Yes
Allowed response types	Yes
User draft response	Yes
Raw CUR	No
Other teams' issues	No
AWS write credentials	No
Catalogue write access	No

The model may return:

- Plain-English explanation.
- Follow-up question.
- Suggested response category.

- Draft summary.
- Confidence or review flag.

The model may not:

- Submit a response without confirmation.
- Write S3.
- Change assignment directly.
- Claim a root cause without evidence.
- Access unrelated data.

Minimum AWS Ask

Area	MVP Ask
Runtime	One private ECS, Lambda, or approved internal app runtime
Auth	Enterprise SSO with email and group claims
Bedrock	Invoke one approved model in one approved region
Network	Private route to Bedrock Runtime, S3, KMS, CloudWatch Logs, Secrets Manager if used
S3 read	Case file prefix only
S3 write	Responses current/history, dashboard export, audit prefixes
KMS	Decrypt case files; encrypt/decrypt written objects
Logs	Runtime logs and business audit events

MVP Success Criteria

Criterion	Evidence
User can respond to a case	Submitted response exists in S3 current prefix
Response is structured	JSON schema validation passes
Dashboard can consume output	Export record appears in dashboard prefix
AI is controlled	Bedrock has no direct S3/catalogue/AWS write path
Access is scoped	Unauthorised user cannot view or submit case
Audit is complete	View, model assist, submit, and export events exist
FinOps review is possible	Dispute and reassignment requests are visible

MVP Build Order

Step	Deliverable
1	Case file schema and sample report item
2	SSO-protected case page
3	Backend read/authorisation path
4	Bedrock explanation and guided response draft
5	Deterministic submit endpoint
6	S3 current/history/export/audit writes
7	Dashboard reads export prefix
8	Pilot with one team and one report period

Final MVP Statement

Build one SSO-protected response portal for one report feed.

Use Bedrock only to explain, ask, classify, and draft.

Use deterministic backend logic for all validation, authorisation, state changes, S3 writes, and audit.

Publish one dashboard-ready S3 export.

Do not remediate, mutate catalogues, inspect live infrastructure, or expose broad cost data.